

Healthy No-Added-Sugar Nuts, Seeds & Berry Barfi / Laddoo

A naturally sweetened festive-style Indian sweet made with dates, nuts, seeds, optional berries, coconut, and khoa or peanut butter. This version is highly customizable, protein-rich, fiber-rich, and works beautifully as barfi, cake bites, or laddoos.

Core Ingredients

- 1 cup soft pitted dates
- 1/4–1/2 cup goji berries OR dried cranberries/blueberries (unsweetened preferred)
- 3 cups mixed roasted nuts (almonds, cashews, walnuts, pistachios, pecans, peanuts)
- 1/2 cup mixed roasted seeds (pumpkin, sunflower, sesame, hemp, flax, chia)
- 1/2 cup crumbled unsweetened khoa OR 1/2 cup desiccated coconut
- 2–3 tbsp ghee
- 1 tsp cardamom powder (elakkai)
- Few saffron strands soaked in 1 tbsp warm milk
- Pinch of salt

Optional Additions

- 1–2 tbsp peanut butter or almond butter
- 2–4 tbsp whey protein isolate (vanilla or unflavored)
- 1 tbsp cocoa powder for chocolate version
- Rose water for floral flavor
- Orange zest for festive variation

Preparation Method

- Dry roast nuts separately until aromatic.
- Dry roast seeds lightly on low heat.
- Allow everything to cool slightly.
- Pulse nuts and seeds into coarse mixture; avoid making butter.
- Chop or grind dates and berries into sticky paste.
- Heat ghee in heavy-bottom pan on low-medium heat.

- Add date-berry mixture and stir until softened.
- Add nuts, seeds, khoa/coconut, cardamom, saffron milk, and salt.
- Mix thoroughly until mixture starts coming together.
- Add peanut butter or whey protein if using.
- If mixture feels dry, add warm milk or hot water 1 tbsp at a time.
- Spread into greased tray for barfi OR shape into laddoos while warm.

Texture Tips & Tweaks

- Use softer Medjool dates for easiest binding.
- Do not over-grind nuts or texture becomes greasy.
- Desiccated coconut gives lighter texture and better shelf life than khoa.
- Whey protein makes mixture firmer as it cools.
- Peanut butter improves softness and binding.
- If mixture becomes too sticky, add extra nut powder or coconut.
- Cooling completely improves slicing.

Interesting Variations

- Chocolate Version: add cocoa powder and dark chocolate chips.
- Rose Pistachio Version: add rose water and extra pistachios.
- Protein Energy Bar Version: add extra whey isolate and press into bars.
- Keto-Low-Date Version: reduce dates and increase nuts/seeds.
- Coconut Saffron Version: increase coconut and saffron.
- Peanut Chikki Style: use more peanuts and sesame.
- Berry Festival Version: use mixed goji, cranberry, blueberry pieces.

Serving Suggestions

- Serve chilled or room temperature.
- Works as tea-time snack or festive sweet.
- Excellent as travel energy bites.
- Can be wrapped individually for gifting.

Approximate Nutrition (Per Small Piece/Laddoo)

- Calories: ~110–160
- Protein: ~4–7g (higher with whey)
- Net Carbs: ~5–9g
- Fiber: ~2–4g
- Fat: ~7–10g

Storage

- Store refrigerated for best freshness.
- Keeps 1–2 weeks refrigerated.
- Can be frozen for longer storage.
- Coconut-only version stores better than khoa version.